JOB SEARCH GUIDE

High-paying software jobs

India search, screens, and offers

LinkedIn · Naukri · Instahyre · Cutshort · company career pages

For a developer with 8 years of .NET experience who wants a tech lead or senior engineer role.

Prepared 31 October 2026. Pay bands below are public market ranges. Verify every number on the live posting and with someone who joined that company recently.

How to use this guide

Read the pay section once and write your floor before you open a job site. Then finish the profile, turn on two LinkedIn alerts and one Naukri alert, and run the weekly system. Use the interview section the day a recruiter calls. Technical practice stays in the 10-day roadmap, the deep dive, and the DSA and system-design guide. Reading postings without a floor fills the week with calls you will decline.

What you are aiming at

You have eight years of delivery on C#, ASP.NET Core, Entity Framework Core, SQL Server, and Azure. The high-paying seat is a tech lead or senior engineer who still designs the API and the data, and who can own a release. The same search steps work if the title on the posting is Senior Software Engineer or Staff Engineer and the scope is that seat.

Positioning line

I have eight years building .NET backends. I am moving into a tech lead role where I still own Web API design, EF Core, SQL, and Azure App Service or Functions, and I also own the technical plan: service boundaries, migration risk, code review, and a safe release.

Say that line, then one proof sentence from your own project: the system, the decision, and the number after the change. The 10-day roadmap is where you practice the rest out loud.

Which document to open

When	Open
You are choosing companies and sending applications	This guide
A recruiter booked a screen	This guide, interview section, plus the positioning line
You have a technical round this week	NET-Tech-Lead-10-Day-Interview-Roadmap, then the deep dive for the weak day
You have a design round	NET-DSA-and-System-Design, plus Day 7 and Day 9 of the roadmap
You are holding two written offers	This guide, offer section

What you will have on paper

1. A pay floor: minimum fixed, target total, cities, work mode, and the notice period you will quote.
2. A list of about 25 companies, mostly product and global capability centers, plus a few services firms only where the posted band clears the floor.
3. One resume, one LinkedIn profile, and one Naukri profile that tell the same story.
4. A tracker with company, source, date, contact, stack, stated band, round, and next action.
5. A 30-day calendar: profile, applications, screens, and offer comparison.

Where the pay comes from

At eight years, the company type moves the offer more than another year of experience. An IT services grade and a global capability center grade can share the title Technical Lead and sit in different bands. Write the band you want before you talk to a recruiter, or the first number spoken on the call becomes the anchor.

Bands to verify, not bands to quote as fact

Public market write-ups in 2026 cluster like the table below for a hands-on technical lead in India. Services roles often sit from the high 20s into the low 40s LPA. Product companies and global capability centers commonly sit from the mid-40s into the mid-80s LPA, with a long tail above that at a few global firms. A single posting, AmbitionBox, and one person who joined that company in the last year beat any average. If a blog and a live offer disagree, trust the offer letter.

Company type	What they pay for	Range to check on the posting
IT services or consulting	Grade, client billing, and tenure. Equity is rare.	High 20s to low 40s LPA total.
Funded product or scale-up	Ownership of a product surface, design, and delivery.	Mid-40s to mid-70s LPA, sometimes ESOP on top.
Global capability center	A global engineering band, production ownership, and compliance work.	Mid-50s to mid-80s LPA. Bonus or RSUs are common.
Fintech or BFSI product	Platform risk plus domain knowledge.	Often the top of the capability-center range. Read the fixed split.

Bengaluru and Hyderabad have the deepest set of product and capability-center roles for this stack. Pune, Chennai, and Delhi NCR have real teams, and the posted band is sometimes lower. A remote-India role may pay the Bengaluru band or a city discount. The posting is the source.

Read an offer as cash, not as one CTC number

Indian offers fold several different payments into cost to company. Compare fixed cash first. Two offers with the same CTC can differ by a few lakhs a year in money that actually arrives.

Line	What it is	What to ask
Fixed	Base pay, paid every month.	This is the number you compare across offers.
Variable	A bonus, often written as up to a percent of fixed.	What did this grade receive last year, and what is the condition?
Employer provident fund	Often counted inside CTC.	Subtract it when you estimate monthly cash.
Gratuity	Often counted inside CTC.	It follows the service rule, commonly five years.
Joining bonus	A one-time payment.	What is the clawback if you leave inside a year?
ESOP or RSU	Equity.	Grant size, vesting, cliff, strike price, and whether anyone has been able to sell.
In-hand	Cash after tax, provident fund, and professional tax.	Estimate it from fixed pay and the annexure, not from CTC divided by 12.

Equity you cannot sell does not pay rent. A large ESOP grant at an early-stage company is a second bet on top of salary. Keep the fixed salary at or above your floor, then treat equity as upside. Ask when tax is due. The offer annexure and a payroll calculator answer the in-hand question for that letter.

Write your floor before the first call

Fill this on paper. Quote these numbers every time. Changing the expected number in a later round, with no new written offer, makes the process harder.

Decision	Write yours
Minimum fixed I will accept	
Target fixed	
Target total CTC	
Cities I will join	Bengaluru, Hyderabad, or the cities you will actually move to
Work mode	Hybrid, on-site, or remote India
Notice period on the contract	30, 60, or 90 days
Earliest realistic joining date	After notice, and after any buyout you have already confirmed

Floor rule

If the recruiter's budget for fixed pay is under your minimum, thank them and close the conversation in that call. A week of rounds will not raise a budget they already stated.

Build a list of about 25 companies

Keep three piles. The first pile is global firms with an India engineering center whose job descriptions already say C#, ASP.NET Core, or .NET. Banks, insurers, healthcare, retail, and Microsoft-stack product teams show up here often. The second pile is product companies, Indian or global, whose posting names your stack. A

careers page full of Java and Go is a weak bet for a C# lead. The third pile is services firms, and only the ones whose posted CTC clears your floor. A famous brand at 22 LPA is a different decision from a capability center inside your target band.

Check the stack in three places: the job description, the LinkedIn headlines of engineers on that team, and the title they are actually hiring. Add a company when at least two of the three match the work you want.

The weekly system

Five tailored applications on a weekday is a full search day. Each application uses the company name, the stack written in that job description, and a resume bullet that matches the work. Spend the same hour on people: recruiter notes and referral asks for those five companies. A saved search plus a referral from an engineer on the team is the path that reaches hiring managers at product companies.

- Monday: refresh alerts, add new posts from the last seven days to the tracker, and pick the five you will finish this week.
- Tuesday and Wednesday: apply on the company career page when the post has one, and send the referral note the same day.
- Thursday: Naukri and LinkedIn messages. Reply the same day to anyone who wrote first.
- Friday: update the tracker, drop roles under your floor, and pick the practice topic from the roadmap for any screen already booked.

Search work is about an hour on a weekday. Interview practice uses the roadmap's longer blocks on the days you have a round. If a week of applications produces no replies, change the headline and the company list before you increase the number of clicks. If every reply is under your floor, raise the salary filter and point the headline at tech lead and product keywords.

Tracker

Keep one sheet. Copy this header. One row per company, updated the day anything happens.

```
Company | Source | Date | Contact | Stack | Stated band | Round | Next action
Northwind Pay | LinkedIn referral | 2 Nov | Asha, engineering manager | ASP.NET Core, Azure SQL |
Fixed 48, total 55 | Recruiter done | Hiring manager Thu 7 pm
```

Source means LinkedIn, Naukri, Instahyre, a career page, or a named employee. Stated band means the number the recruiter said, split into fixed and variable when they told you. Next action is a date, not a feeling.

Read a job description in five minutes

1. Employer, city, work mode, and the notice period they prefer.
2. The poster. If a consultancy posted it, the workplace is the client. Ask for the client name before you invest a round.
3. The core stack. Apply when you have C#, ASP.NET Core, SQL, and one cloud, even if you lack one tool on a long wish list.

4. Years. A range of 6 to 12 includes eight years. Apply.
5. The band, if they printed one. Compare it with your floor before you tailor the resume.

Prioritize posts from the last seven days. A popular company can already be mid-process on a post older than two weeks. Apply if the stack matches, and send a note to a person on the team the same day.

The profile recruiters search

LinkedIn, Naukri, and a human recruiter all look for the same words: the title you want, C#, ASP.NET Core, SQL, Azure, and a number that proves you shipped. Put those words in the headline, the skills, the last two roles, and the resume file. A profile that says Software Engineer, and a resume that says Tech Lead, looks like two different people.

Resume

One page if the last two roles tell the story. Two pages if eight years of relevant work needs the second page. Export a text PDF from Word. The file name is Firstname-Lastname-Tech-Lead-NET.pdf. Single column. Standard headings: Summary, Skills, Work Experience, Education. Skip text boxes, icons, and a photo. Name, phone, email, city, and the LinkedIn URL are enough in the header. Family details and a full street address do not help a product or capability-center screen.

Summary, three lines: years, stack, domain, and one outcome. Skills, one block: only tools you can explain on a screen. If Kubernetes is listed, you can describe a deployment you ran. Work experience in reverse date order. Each role shows company, title, city, and dates, then three to five bullets. Education sits at the end.

Bullet shape

Verb, system, what you changed, and the number after. Cut p95 on the order API from 800 ms to 220 ms by replacing an N+1 EF Core query with one SQL query and a covering index.

Other bullets that score: a migration with the date the old runtime was gone, a review rule the team still uses, a production rollback you chose, a person who now owns a service you used to own. The story bank in the roadmap is the source. Leave sample stories as structure. Write your own systems and your own numbers.

Headline you can paste

```
Tech Lead | C# ASP.NET Core | Azure SQL Server | 8 years
```

Use that pattern on the resume header, the LinkedIn headline, and the Naukri resume headline. Swap in the domain if the target list is mostly one industry, for example fintech or healthcare, and only if you have shipped in it.

Skills to list when you have done the work

Recruiters search the words written in job descriptions. ASP.NET Core and .NET are both searched. Web API and REST are both searched. Use the name you have earned, spelled the way the posting spells it.

- C#, .NET, ASP.NET Core, Web API, Entity Framework Core
- SQL Server, T-SQL, Azure, Azure App Service, Azure Functions
- Microservices, REST, Git, CI/CD, system design, code review

- Add Docker, Kubernetes, Service Bus, or Microsoft Entra ID only where you can defend them

Fifteen to thirty skills is enough on Naukri. A list of every tool you opened once pushes the real ones down. Match the list to two or three tech-lead job descriptions you would accept, then delete the rest.

LinkedIn About, first three lines

Only the first lines show before someone clicks See more. Put the search words there.

```
Tech lead with 8 years on C#, ASP.NET Core, EF Core, SQL Server, and Azure.
I design the API and the data, and I own the release plan, review quality, and migration risk.
Looking for a tech lead or senior engineer role in Bengaluru or Hyderabad. Notice period 30 days.
```

Replace the cities and the notice with yours. The experience section uses the same bullets as the resume. Dates match the resume. A gap or a contract role is written the way it happened. Background verification later checks titles, dates, and compensation against the letter, the pay slips, and Form 16.

What you leave off

- A public Open to Work photo frame while you are employed. Use the recruiter-only setting, described in the LinkedIn section.
- Client names, revenue figures, or architecture you are not allowed to share. Describe the system class and the metric you are allowed to share.
- A second headline for a different career. One search, one story: .NET tech lead.

Numbers you can show

Quote the current CTC you can point to on an offer letter, pay slips, or Form 16. Inflating current pay is a common reason an offer is withdrawn during background verification.

LinkedIn

LinkedIn is the referral channel and the place global capability centers and product companies post senior roles. The Jobs tab is the feed. The hire happens when a recruiter or an engineer at the company opens your profile, or when an employee submits you. Build the profile, save two searches, and spend most of the hour on people.

Open to work, recruiters only

On your profile, open the Open to control and choose finding a new job. Set visibility to recruiters only. Add titles: Tech Lead, Technical Lead, Senior Software Engineer, Staff Software Engineer. Add the cities you will join, full-time, and a start date that matches your notice. Leave the public photo frame off while you are employed. Recruiters with a LinkedIn Recruiter seat can still find the private signal. Your coworkers will not see a green banner on your photo.

Two searches to save

Open Jobs. Paste one query into the keyword box. Set the location to a city you will join, or run a second pass with India and Remote. Set Date posted to Past week. Set Experience level to Mid-Senior. Some lead roles are tagged Director, so check that filter once a week as well. Set the workplace type to hybrid, on-site, or remote to match your floor. Sort by most recent. For the first pass, leave the Easy Apply filter off so you see posts that name a team and link to a career page.

Tech lead query

```
("Tech Lead" OR "Technical Lead" OR "Engineering Lead" OR "Staff Engineer") AND (".NET" OR "C#" OR
"ASP.NET") AND (Azure OR "SQL Server")
```

Senior engineer query

Use this when the company pays lead money under a senior title.

```
("Senior Software Engineer" OR "Senior Engineer" OR "Staff Engineer") AND (".NET" OR "C#") AND
(Azure OR "ASP.NET Core")
```

Save both searches and turn the alert on, daily. When the mail arrives, add the matches that clear your floor to the tracker the same day. A keyword search also works as plain text if the boolean form returns nothing: .NET Tech Lead Azure, then ASP.NET Core Senior Engineer.

What to do with one posting

1. Read the description with the five-minute check in the pay section. Stop if the band or the city misses your floor.
2. Find the hiring company. Open People at that company. Filter to engineering, or to a title that contains recruiter or talent acquisition.

3. Apply on the company career page when the post links to one. LinkedIn Easy Apply is the path when you cannot find an employee and there is no career-page link.
4. Ask one engineer for a referral the same day, with the message below. A referral while the post is in its first week reaches the manager with the application.

Notes you can send

A free connection note is short, about 200 characters. Use the person's name. State stack, notice, and city. Skip a life story.

```
Hi Asha, I have 8 years in C#, ASP.NET Core, EF Core, and Azure. I am looking for a tech lead role.
Notice is 30 days, Bengaluru hybrid. Happy to talk if you are hiring.
```

Referral ask, after they accept or if you already know them. Attach the job link yourself. Give them three lines they can paste.

```
I am applying for the .NET Tech Lead role (link). Three lines you can forward: 8 years on ASP.NET
Core and Azure; I led a SQL change that cut p95 from 800 ms to 220 ms; I can join in 30 days. If
you are comfortable referring me, I will send the resume.
```

Replace the metric with yours. Send the resume as the same PDF you uploaded everywhere else. If they do not reply in a week, leave it. One follow-up is enough. Move to the next person on the list.

Who to message

- A recruiter or talent partner whose current company is the hiring company, and whose posts mention engineering.
- An engineering manager on the stack you want. This is the strongest referral when they reply.
- An engineer you studied or worked with. A specific job link makes the ask easy to forward.
- Alumni filters help when you share a college or a past employer. Mention that in the first line.

Ten new notes a week, plus replies the same day, is enough alongside five applications. Connect with people you can speak to about a real role. A large connection count with no conversations does not change who calls you.

Profile details that help this search

- Headline and About from the profile section. Featured can hold the resume PDF. Skip confidential design documents.
- Experience bullets match the resume, including months and years.
- Skills: pin ASP.NET Core, C#, Azure, SQL, and technical leadership. Colleagues can endorse later. The words matter more than the endorsement count.
- Open to work preferences match the titles in your saved searches, so recruiter search and your own search point at the same seat.

When a recruiter messages you

Reply the same day with three facts: the title you want, your notice, and your city. Ask for the job description, the band, and whether the team is their own product or a client. Take the screen when the band can clear your floor. The interview section has the words for current CTC, expected CTC, and notice.

Naukri

Naukri is the high-volume board. Services firms, capability centers, and consultancies search it every day. You get a call in two ways: you apply to a posted job, or a recruiter finds your profile in their resume database and writes or calls. The second path is where a complete profile matters. Recruiters filter by keywords, years of experience, city, current or expected salary, notice period, and how recently the profile was modified. Miss one filter and you are absent from that search.

Fill the fields they filter on

Open your profile and finish these. The resume file, the headline, and the employment text should match the LinkedIn story word for word on the stack and the metrics.

- Resume headline: Tech Lead | C# ASP.NET Core | Azure SQL Server | 8 years.
- Key skills: 15 to 30 skills from the profile section, copied from tech-lead job descriptions you would accept. Spell ASP.NET Core, C#, and SQL Server the way those posts spell them.
- Summary: the same three lines as LinkedIn About, plus whether a notice buyout is realistic.
- Employment: the same companies, titles, dates, and bullets as the resume.
- Current salary: the real CTC. Expected salary: the lowest total you will actually discuss. A higher expected salary hides you from searches capped under that figure. A lower one fills the phone with roles under your floor. Explain the fixed and variable split on the call.
- Notice period: the real number of days. Preferred work location: only cities you will join.
- Attach the text PDF resume. A profile with no file looks unfinished to the person scanning results.
- Set the profile visible to recruiters. Block your current employer so their recruiters do not open you.

Recruiter search can require all keywords, any keyword, or an exclude list. Synonyms do not save you. If they search ASP.NET Core and your profile only says web development, you do not appear. Put the precise tool names on the headline, the key skills, and the most recent role.

Stay in the recently modified filter

Recruiters prefer profiles that were updated recently, because a profile last touched eight months ago is often not looking. Make one true edit on weekday mornings: a metric you can now state, a skill reordered to match the roles you want this week, or the notice line. Save. Then apply. A fake keystroke is unnecessary when the resume is still gaining real bullets from the story bank.

How to search jobs

Use the keyword box with a title and the stack. Set experience so eight years sits inside the range, for example 6 to 12. Set location to your cities. Set a minimum salary at your floor so mass postings under that number drop out. Sort by date. Read Last 1 day and Last 3 days first, then Last 7 days.

```
.NET Tech Lead
ASP.NET Core Azure
C# Technical Lead
```

Run those as separate searches. Save an alert for each. Prefer a post from the hiring company's own recruiter when you recognize the brand. A consultancy post is worth a call when they will name the client and the CTC clears your floor. Apply in the first one or two days after the post goes up. Later applications sit under a large applicant count.

The recruiter call

Answer or reply the same day. Have your floor and your notice written in front of you. Ask these before you send more documents.

1. Is this your company's product, or a client project? What is the client name?
2. What is the budget for fixed pay, and what is the variable?
3. What stack does the team ship this quarter?
4. How many rounds are there, and who sits on the panel?
5. Is there a bond, a buyout, or a training fee?

If they will not name the hiring company, end the call and write that in the tracker. If the fixed budget is under your floor, end the call. Send the standard resume only after the role is real. Several consultancies sometimes submit the same person to one client. If you already know the client name and you are in process through someone else, say so. A double submission can get the application rejected.

Documents and fees

Send pay slips and identity documents to a named company during a real process. A first caller who demands Aadhaar, a fee, a training charge, or a laptop deposit is a stop. Naukri paid add-ons, including resume-writing upsells, are optional. Finish the free profile and a week of applications before you consider paying. A clearer headline changes who calls. A paid badge does not repair a vague one.

Keywords that match this search

Add these to skills and to the last role when they are true. Recruiters type them as all-keywords, meaning every word must appear.

They type	You also keep the long form
.NET, C#	ASP.NET Core, Web API
SQL	SQL Server, Entity Framework Core
Azure	App Service, Functions, or the service you actually run
Lead	Tech Lead on the headline, and the team size in a bullet
Microservices	Only if you can draw the boundary and the failure

The interview section covers what you say when they ask current CTC, expected CTC, and notice. Those three answers should match the numbers stored on this profile.

The other job sites

Finish LinkedIn, Naukri, and one specialist profile before you open another site. Three complete profiles beat eight half-filled ones. Use the same resume PDF, the same headline, and the same salary floor everywhere.

Site	Use it for	Do this week
LinkedIn	Referrals, product companies, capability centers, senior titles.	Profile, two daily alerts, ten notes.
Naukri	Volume, services, capability centers, consultant reach.	Full profile, salary and notice filled, alerts, fresh posts.
Instahyre	Inbound interest from product companies and mid-senior roles.	A detailed profile and a salary. Reply to matches the same day.
Cutshort	Startups and a direct note to the hiring side.	Roles that show a band at or above your floor.
Wellfound	Early-stage startups that print salary and equity.	Read the fixed salary before you read the grant.
Hirist	A tech-only feed for experienced engineers.	The same resume, plus an alert for .NET lead.
Company career pages	The 25-company list.	Apply there when the public post points at the company site.
Indeed and Foundit	Listings that never reached the boards above.	One saved search each. Skip the rest of the long tail.

Instahyre

Instahyre is a match profile more than a board you scroll all day. You write a detailed profile, including work, skills, and the salary you want. Companies that match reach out. A thin profile gets few conversations. Put the same bullets and the same stack you used on LinkedIn. Set the salary at your floor so the matches start in range. Reply the same day a company expresses interest. Use a personal email. Use the site's confidentiality controls so your current employer is not browsing you.

This channel fits someone with several years of shipped work who wants product companies. The quality of the profile does the filtering. Chasing every match under your floor trains the search in the wrong direction. Decline those in one line and keep the floor.

Cutshort and Wellfound

Cutshort is useful when a startup will talk to you directly and the listing shows a band. Send the same short note you use on LinkedIn: stack, years, notice, city, and the role you want. If the product uses credits or coins for messages, spend them on roles at or above your floor.

Wellfound, the startup board that grew out of AngelList Talent, often shows salary and equity on the post. That saves a screen. Early-stage equity is a bet. Compare the fixed salary with your floor first. Ask the vesting, the cliff, the strike, and whether any employee has sold shares. A grant with no path to cash stays in the upside column of your tracker.

Hirist, Indeed, and Foundit

Hirist is a tech-only board aimed at experienced engineers. Upload the same PDF and save a search for .NET tech lead in your cities. Indeed India and Foundit catch company listings that never appeared on LinkedIn. One alert on each is enough. If a role is already in your tracker from another source, update that row. A second account of the same company wastes the weekly five.

Career pages on the target list

For each of the 25 companies, open the careers site once a week. Search .NET, C#, and tech lead. Apply on that site when the role is open, then send one referral ask on LinkedIn the same day. A career-page application plus an employee referral is the combination product companies already know how to process. Record the confirmation mail in the tracker.

Remote roles and dollar contracts

Add one remote channel only if evening overlap with US hours is acceptable. That can be a company's India-remote job, or a vetted marketplace such as Turing. Decide the hours before you apply. A dollar rate on a contract is a different shape from an India CTC with provident fund. Ask who employs you, who pays you, and who handles tax: the marketplace, an employer-of-record, or the company itself. Put the monthly cash next to your floor before you compare it with a local offer.

Order of work

Week one is LinkedIn, Naukri, and either Instahyre or Cutshort. Week two adds career pages for the target list. Open Hirist, Wellfound, Indeed, or Foundit after those three profiles are complete. Leave the rest of the internet job boards alone until this system is producing conversations.

Interview tips

Indian loops for this level follow a familiar path. The words change by company. The decisions do not. Clear each round by showing the next person that you can do the job they are screening for. Technical depth is practiced in the 10-day roadmap, the deep dive, and the DSA and system-design guide. This section is how you carry that work into the process.

Round	What they decide	What you prepare
Recruiter screen	Title, stack, city, notice, and whether pay can meet.	Floor, notice, positioning line, and one proof metric.
Hiring manager	Scope, judgment, and whether they can work with you.	One project deep dive and a 90-day sketch.
Coding or practical .NET	Whether you can still build.	Roadmap Days 1, 3, 4, and 5. Speak while you type.
System design	Boundaries, data, failure, and rollback.	DSA and system-design guide, plus roadmap Days 7 and 9.
Leadership	A real decision and how the team works now.	Five stories from your own career, in the roadmap's story bank.
HR or offer	Joining date, location, and the letter.	The same CTC numbers as the first screen.

Before every screen, write three lines on paper: the company type, why you want this role, and the one project you will tell. Score practice answers the way the roadmap says. A strong answer is correct, names a tradeoff, and names a consequence for a user, an on-call person, a cost, or a teammate.

Tell me about yourself

Ninety seconds. The positioning line, then one proof sentence, then the role you want. Stop.

```
I have eight years building .NET backends. I am moving into a tech lead role where I still own Web
API design, EF Core, SQL, and Azure, and I also own the technical plan: service boundaries,
migration risk, code review, and a safe release.
In the last system I owned, we cut p95 on the order API from 800 ms to 220 ms with one SQL query
and a covering index.
I am looking for that scope on a product team in Bengaluru. My notice is 30 days.
```

Replace the middle sentence with your system and your number. Practice it out loud until it fits in ninety seconds.

Current CTC, expected CTC, and notice

Every Indian screen asks these. Answer with the breakup. The numbers match the resume, Naukri, and the documents you can show later.

Current pay

My fixed is A lakh. Variable is B, and last year it paid W. The CTC on my letter is T. I can walk through that on a slip if we reach an offer.

Expected pay

For a tech lead seat I compare offers on fixed cash first. I am targeting fixed around F, and a total that can land near N once variable and equity are clear. If you have a band for this role, tell me the band and I will say whether it fits.

Notice

My contract notice is N days. I can start the process now and join on date D. I will confirm any early release only after this offer is written.

If they demand a single expected number and will not share a band, give your target fixed and say the total depends on variable and equity. Keep that number at or above your floor. A thirty-day notice is a hiring advantage. If your contract says ninety days, quote ninety. Add a buyout or an early release only when you have done it before or your manager has already agreed. A promised date you cannot hit shows up when the background check asks your current HR for the last working day.

The rest of the screen

- Why are you looking: the scope you want next. Tech lead ownership of the API, the data, Azure, and the release plan.
- Why this company: one fact about their product, one line from the job description, and the part of that scope you have already done.
- Other processes: name the stage you are in. Cite another offer only when you can forward the letter.
- A weakness: one real gap and the practice you do now. For example, you used to jump to a new service. You now write the data owner and the failure mode first, and you keep one deployable until those are clear.

The reason you give for looking is the work you want. A complaint about a manager becomes the story they remember. Save the detail for a private decision about whether you join.

Hiring manager

They already believe you know C#. They are testing judgment. Walk one project from the story bank: the constraint, the decision, the metric, and what the team does now. When they ask what you would do in ninety days, say you will learn the production pain from the on-call notes and the last incidents, ship one improvement the team already wants, and write the review or release check that would have caught it. That sketch shows you can lead without pretending you know their system on day one.

Coding, design, and leadership

On a coding round, ask what the input size is and what should happen on bad input. Narrate the approach, then type. Days 1, 3, 4, and 5 of the roadmap cover the C#, ASP.NET Core, EF Core, and SQL they still test. The DSA guide covers the structures. If you go blank, say what you would look up and which part you do know. Invented API limits and invented Azure prices lose the room. The roadmap already says to name the document or the metric you would check.

On a design round, draw one boundary, the data owner, the failure, and the rollback. Days 7 and 9, and the system-design guide, are the practice. Stop adding services when one deployable still fits.

On a leadership round, use your five stories: a production incident and the minute you chose rollback or fix-forward, a slow endpoint and the number after the fix, a migration and what you refused to rewrite, a design you pushed back on, and a person who now owns something you used to own. Each story needs your decision and a metric.

Questions you ask them

Three questions are enough. Pick from this list based on what they did not already answer.

- Who owns this service in production, and what does the on-call week look like?
- What is the deploy path, and how do you roll back?
- Why is the role open, and what should I own in the first ninety days?
- How large is the team, and which decisions does the tech lead make without a committee?
- What does a strong first year in this seat look like?

The day of the interview

- A quiet room, a charged laptop, and the IDE open on an empty console project.
- A SQL tool ready if they said the round includes the database. Paper for a design. Water. Phone on silent.
- Join five minutes early. If you need a moment to think, say you are taking a moment, then start with the decision or the definition.
- Write down every question you missed as soon as you hang up. That list is the next practice hour.

After the round

Send a short note the same day to the recruiter or the person who arranged the call. One specific point from the conversation is enough.

```
Thank you for today's conversation about the order API and the release process. I enjoyed the
discussion of how the team rolls back. I am glad to continue, and my notice is 30 days.
```

Take-home work

A time-boxed exercise of a few hours, reviewed by the hiring manager, is a normal part of some loops. Ask how long they expect and who marks it. A multi-day build that matches their live product, or unpaid work they could ship to a client, is outside a hiring exercise. Decline that and offer a design discussion or a shorter sample instead.

Stop the process

Walk away from a joining bond, a training fee, salary offered in cash outside the letter, a recruiter who will not name the client, or anyone who asks you to resign before a written offer. A stack that changes completely after you send documents is a different job. Put it back through the five-minute check.

The offer

Compare fixed cash first. Then variable and the condition that pays it. Then joining bonus and the clawback. Then equity: grant, vesting, cliff, strike, and whether anyone has sold. Then provident fund, insurance, probation length, and the notice period after you join. A verbal number is a conversation. The letter is the offer.

Line	Offer A	Offer B
Fixed pay		
Variable and when it paid last year		
Joining bonus and clawback		
Equity: vesting, cliff, strike, sale path		
Provident fund, gratuity, insurance		
Probation and notice after joining		
City and weekly office days		
Joining date they will accept		

Accept in writing after the letter matches what you agreed. Resign after that written acceptance. Serve the notice your current contract requires. If they run background verification, the titles, dates, and CTC you quoted should match the papers. Complete the checks they schedule. Tell your current manager when you are ready to serve notice, with the joining date already backed by the new letter.

How to ask for a change

A competing written offer is the lever that moves fixed pay. Mail one clear ask. Get the change on the revised letter. A chat message is not the annexure.

```
Thank you for the offer. I want to join this team. To sign, I need fixed pay of F lakh, or a
joining bonus of J that closes the gap with the other written offer I am holding. I can sign by
Friday if the revised letter reflects that.
```

Send that only when the other offer is real and you would show it. If they cannot move fixed pay, ask for a joining bonus or a written review date, and decide against your floor. Quote the same current CTC you gave in the first screen.

Thirty days

Run this once. If a screen arrives in week one, pull the interview practice forward and keep the daily applications smaller that day. The roadmap's practice blocks are 3.5 to 4 hours. Search days stay near an hour so you still have voice left for the technical work.

Week	Focus	Done when
1	Resume, LinkedIn, Naukri, and either Instahyre or Cutshort. Write the floor. List about 25 companies. Turn on alerts.	The three profiles tell the same story, and the tracker has its header row.
2	Five tailored applications each weekday. Ten recruiter or hiring-manager notes. Five referral asks with a job link. Log every conversation.	Every target-company application has a source and a next action.
3	Recruiter screens with the CTC script. Ninety-second answers from the roadmap. One design spoken from the system-design guide. One story from your own project each day.	You can give current pay, expected pay, and notice without looking down, and one project without wandering.
4	Hiring-manager and panel rounds. Fill the offer table when letters arrive. Ask for the change you need. Resign after the written acceptance.	The tracker shows either a signed letter or a dated next round.

If the month ends without an offer

Count conversations, not clicks. No replies means the headline, the cities, or the company list needs a rewrite. Replies under the floor means the salary filter and the services pile need a cut. Screens that stall on design or on stories mean the next month is the roadmap and the system-design guide, spoken, while the five applications a day continue. The search keeps running while you practice.

Keep the floor written on the tracker. The high-paying offer is the one that clears it on fixed cash, in a team whose stack you already named out loud, with a letter you can sign.